her from this position for personal reasons. The Council of Ministers complied and thanked her for her ‘many years of responsible work as a member of the Council of Ministers and as minister of public education’.) Other departures included Kurt Hager and Erich Mielke, who was left a broken man, devoid of his unscrupulous finesse. Watching events unfold, Wolf Biermann – the musician unceremoniously banned from returning to the GDR in the 1970s – mocked the ‘unbelievable speed with which the old bastards’ were transforming themselves.5

For Krenz the news got steadily worse, as over a million protestors spilled into Alexanderplatz on 4 November. Watching events from the Interflug building, novelist Stefan Heym said it was as if someone had thrown open the windows after years of ‘stagnation, after years of dullness and mustiness, of phrase-mongering and bureaucratic despotism’. On the sixth, growing discontent sent half a million exuberant marchers to the streets and squares of Leipzig demanding an end to the SED’s monopoly on power, and more significantly, reunification with the West, instead of the hitherto call for reform in the GDR.

The hostility stunned Günter Schabowski, who later reflected, ‘We had engineered a palace revolution without offering a real alternative. We had not swiftly and thoroughly enough whittled away from Stalin’s methods.’6 However, while the demonstrations were going on, an SED working committee did privately agree to announce passport holders would be able to emigrate or just simply visit the West from 10 November.

Schabowski – now acting as a government spokesman – made a monumental blunder on 9 November during a fateful press conference by mistakenly announcing at 6.53 pm that ‘effective immediately, without delay’ – all citizens were free to travel to the West without prerequisites, conditions, or family relationships. What he should have said is that the new rules would be enacted at four o’clock the next day, 10 November, in an ‘orderly manner’ when passport offices and checkpoints were open.7

After a few brief moments of bafflement and confusion, the news hit the Associated Press wire at 7.05 pm and was relayed by GDR TV at 7.30 pm and West German TV at 8 pm, prompting a sudden rush to border crossings. A few hours later, ARD newsreader Hanns Joachim Friedrichs told viewers: